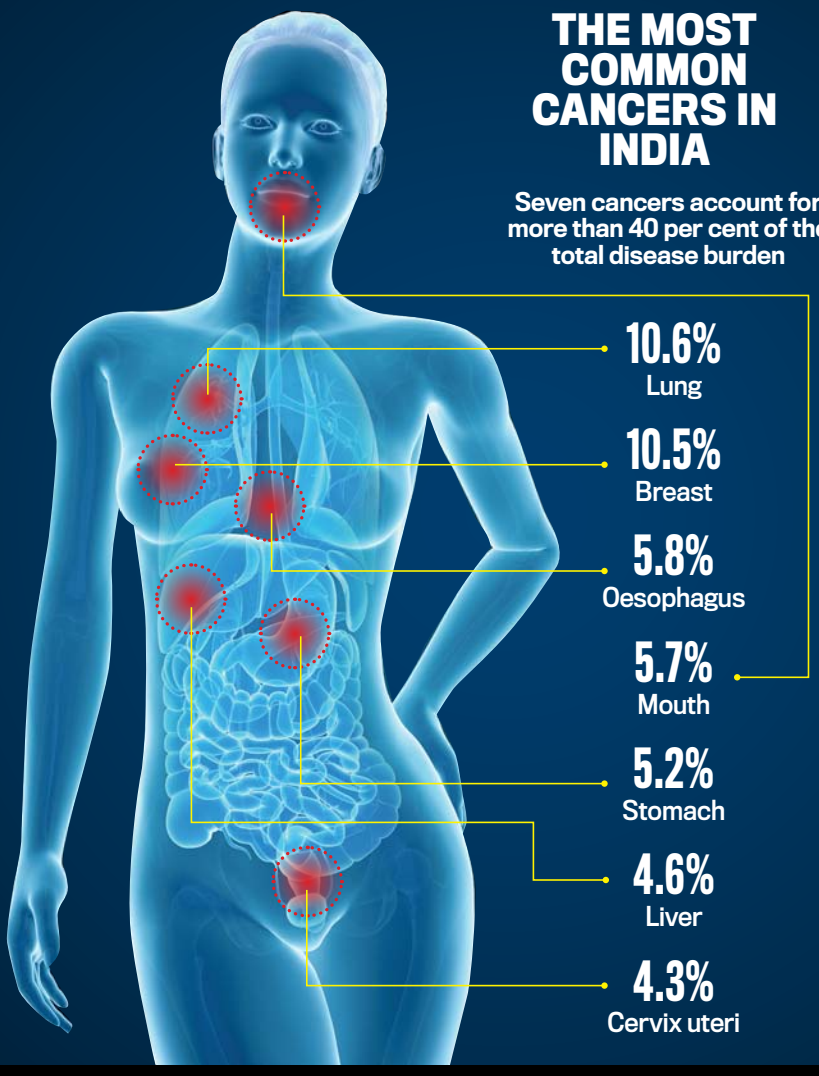


THE MOST COMMON CANCERS IN INDIA

Seven cancers account for more than 40 per cent of the total disease burden

- **10.6%** Lung
- **10.5%** Breast
- **5.8%** Oesophagus
- **5.7%** Mouth
- **5.2%** Stomach
- **4.6%** Liver
- **4.3%** Cervix uteri

THE MOST COMMONLY USED TREATMENTS FOR CANCER IN INDIA

The conventional approaches to treat cancer and their side-effects

CHEMOTHERAPY



What: A drug-based treatment using chemicals to kill cancerous cells

Side effects: Unfortunately, the chemicals affect other cells too, causing hair loss, insomnia, fatigue, lowered appetite and body pain, among other things

RADIOTHERAPY

What: A patient is exposed to high doses of radiation to kill cancer cells and shrink tumours

Side effects: Like chemo, this too can impact healthy cells in the body, causing fatigue, headaches, nausea and skin changes

SURGERY

What: If isolated in a single area, surgery is often used to entirely remove the tumour and surrounding cells

Challenges: The cancer being in a sensitive area, like the brain. Moreover, if caught at a late stage, doctors recommend surgery with other treatment to ensure cancer hasn't spread and that no cancerous cell is left in the body



have the receptors for the hormones estrogen and progesterone and the protein HER2), as well as a high number of oral cancer cases among women. According to the World Health Organization's World Cancer Report 2020, India had 1.16 million new cancer cases across ages and sexes in 2018, and 2.26 million cases of patients with the condition for over five years. In 2020, close to 770,230 people died from the disease in India, as the response to a parliamentary question revealed in 2022. This is almost seven times the number of people who died from Covid in 2020. In an even more alarming finding, a 2022 ICMR (Indian Council of Medical Research) study on the burden of cancers in India, published in the *BMC Cancer* journal, estimates that India is likely to have 29.8 million cancer cases by 2025. That will be 2 per cent of the 1.4 billion population that NITI Aayog estimates India will have by that year. The ICMR study attributes 40 per cent of the cases to one of these seven cancers—of the lung, breast, oesophagus, mouth, stomach, liver and cervix uteri.

With rising disease comes an increasing cost burden. A Tata Memorial study in 2022 calculated that India spent nearly Rs 2,385 crore in 2020 on oral cancer treatment alone through insurance, government, private sector spending, out of pocket payments, and/ or charitable donations. The same study predicts that this economic burden will escalate to Rs 23,724 crore over the next 10 years, and that is without taking inflation into account.

Enter immunotherapy. Cancer research in the past few

"The body has a mechanism to rid itself of disease. In cancer, somehow it gets stalled. A lot of the new treatments prime the body to dispense of the cancerous cells"



DR LALIT KUMAR
Chairperson, Oncology, Artemis Hospitals, Gurugram